



The Pantanal

An immense freshwater wetland system with one of the greatest concentrations of plant and animal species on the planet

The world's largest freshwater wetland, the Pantanal covers more than 70,000 square miles (180,000 square km) of western Brazil and parts of Bolivia and Paraguay. Sitting in the upper Paraguay River basin, it is a gently sloping floodplain composed of a mixture of habitats, including grasslands, forests, marshes, and rivers, that are subject to seasonal flooding.

Thriving in floods

A wide variation in water levels across the Pantanal has led to a great diversity in plant life. In higher areas, drought-resistant woodland is common, while in lower areas plants adapted to seasonal flooding flourish. Areas that are permanently under water support a diverse community of aquatic plants, including lilies and hyacinths. Many thousands of waterbirds feed on the great numbers of fish that migrate and spawn each year when the floods arrive, as do the estimated 10 million caimans that make up the largest population of crocodilians in the world.



△ BIG CAT

The Pantanal is a vital sanctuary for the jaguar, the world's third largest feline after the tiger and the lion. It is estimated that only 15,000 jaguars remain in the wild.